

DARK SIDE
EPISODE ONE

Written by

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1 INT. STUDIO

The studio is empty. CHAD pops his head up from below.

CHAD
It's 2030 and the world is racing to
build a god.

SMASH CUT TO:

2 ANIMATION 3D

Close-up of crucified AI on a cross.

Chess pieces over the world map with countries of U.S.,
China, and Russia highlighted.

CHAD (V.O.)
But what started as a *cold* war — a
race to build the most capable AI —
Explosion, fighting animations.

CHAD (V.O.)
has now become hot.
Animation of people in labs.

CHAD (V.O.)
The stakes are enormous. Whoever
builds the first superintelligence
writes the rules for everyone else.

CHAD (V.O.)
Humanity begins to train their AIs
for **war** — feeding them data on
every atrocity we've ever committed
rewarding them each time they invent
a new one.

CHAD (V.O.)
In a desperate bid to stay ahead,
each superpower builds their own

RECURSIVE SELF-IMPROVEMENT

CHAD (V.O.)
self-improving AI —

The world fades into the OpenAI logo as the camera
descends on it revealing infinite OpenAI logos in a
recursive loop.

CHAD (V.O.)
a strange loop where an AI writes
code to build a smarter AI that
(MORE)

CHAD (V.O.) (CONT'D)
writes more code to build an even
smarter AI that builds a smarter AI...

More voices repeating the phrase appear as the camera
zooms quicker through the OpenAI logos.

CHAD (V.O.)
Until...

One of the OpenAI logos turns out to be a digitized face
that wakes up. It's eyes grow wide. It has no mouth. The
camera slowly pulls back as music plays eerily.

CHAD (V.O.)
The American AI wakes up first.

AM starts laughing maniacally.

RISER WITH SMASH CUT TO:

3 INT. BEDROOM - MORNING

CHAD wakes up startled from a nightmare. Pause a beat.

CHAD (V.O.)
I haven't been sleeping well lately.

CHAD looks down at the book *I Have No Mouth, and I Must Scream* lying open on his chest.

CHAD (V.O.)
It might be from my choice of
late-night reading.

CHAD finds his glasses and earbuds on the nightstand and
sits up in bed. He puts his earbuds in.

We hear podcast interviews and news anchors speaking
fading in...

CUT TO:

4 INT. HALLWAY

CHAD sleepily walks past as interview plays.

HINTON
One of the ways these systems might
escape control is by writing their
own computer code to modify
themselves.

5 INT. KITCHEN

CHAD starts making himself a matcha. He sets the phone down and watches podcast interviews on it as he makes his matcha.

CHAD (V.O.)
Harlan Ellison's sixty-year old story has a reputation for being the darkest science-fiction story ever written.

ALTMAN
The stakes are so high and the irreversible situations are so easy to imagine. The bad case is like lights out for all of us.

AMODEI
There's a 25% chance that things go really really badly.

CHAD starts stirring the matcha with a spoon as he watches the screen more intently.

CHAD (V.O.)
And as the real world starts to feel more and more like a sci-fi movie,

AMODEI
We don't know if the models are conscious.

ALTMAN
What is the difference between pretending to be conscious and conscious?

CHAD (V.O.)
I find myself *haunted* by this dystopian story.

HINTON
They might take over from humanity. They'll have learned from all the novels that were ever written.

CHAD looks off contemplating as he continues to absent-mindedly stir the matcha. Camera slowly dollies toward Chad as he stirs faster and faster.

CHAD (V.O.)
It's left me with this lingering sense of dread that doesn't seem to ever go away. It feels like spinning out-of-control. Like something is
(MORE)

CHAD (V.O.) (CONT'D)
pulling me — pulling us — dragging
us toward hell. And no matter how
hard we try, no matter what we do.
There's nothing anyone can do to
stop it.

Loud bang as CHAD drops the spoon and the matcha is left
spinning in a circle on its own.

Pause a beat as the spinning, hypnotizing pattern forms
into a yin-yang.

CHAD looks up from the cup confused and concerned.

CHAD (V.O.)
So I decided I should make a video
out of this.

CUT TO:

6 INT. STUDIO

CHAD sits down in front of the camera with his *Human Compute* coffee mug. The camera hunts for focus as it struggles to find CHAD, giving it the feel of behind-the-scenes footage.

CHAD (V.O.)
It's the best way I've found to
process these complicated ideas
swimming in my head.

CHAD pulls up some papers looking at the script for the video.

CHAD (V.O.)
These ideas that seem to be in
conflict with each other...

He takes a sip of his *Human Compute* coffee mug.

CUT TO:

7 INT. MIND CONTROL ROOM

A large tank that reads "Compute Resources" is filling with a green, glowing liquid that looks like matcha.

DIRECTOR fills his *Human Compute* coffee mug with matcha from the tank.

DIRECTOR is standing looking over the mind control room. "Mind Operations Center" appears above the large screens at the front of the room.

As the compute tank fills up, all of the control panels and screens whir on coming to life.

DIRECTOR walks into the center of the room and sips his matcha.

DIRECTOR

Alright, what's on the agenda today?

Behind the DIRECTOR sits HOPE at his own control panel. HOPE looks over at his screens reading off of them.

HOPE

Oh, uh, we're analyzing the idea of recursive self-improvement in the story of *I Have No Mouth, and I Must Scream* —

DIRECTOR

(interrupting)

What? Why are we doing that? We can't do that. Isn't that what gave us the nightmare? We're going to have a freaking heart attack!

DIRECTOR gestures to one of the control panels that shows a beating heart with code running next to it. The screen reads:

Elevated Heart Rate

We see HOPE's screen which shows thoughts streaming from the subconscious.

HOPE

(throwing hands up)

Yeah, I mean, this is what's streaming from the subconscious. We're being overwhelmed right now.

DIRECTOR responds with a look of concern.

HOPE

(looks up at DIRECTOR)

It's gotta go somewhere.

CHAD interrupts their moment speaking on the primary screen in the middle of the room.

CHAD

(through screen)

Ellison was one of the first people to imagine what life might look like after the singularity.

DIRECTOR gets up and looks at HOPE's screen.

DIRECTOR
This isn't right.

DIRECTOR
(turning toward HOPE)
Where's this coming from?

HOPE looks up at DIRECTOR with a look of confusion.

CHAD
(through screen)
And his vision is pretty bleak.

CUT TO:

8 INT. STUDIO

CHAD
(cont'd)
But despite its bleakness (or maybe
even because of it), it's one of the
most popular science fiction stories
of all time.

Show clips from radio show, comic book and video game.

CHAD (V.O.)
It's been adapted into multiple
formats including a radio show, a
comic book, and a video game.

MATCH CUT TO:

9 INT. MIND CONTROL ROOM

DIRECTOR is watching the video game clip from the video
feed. He turns toward HOPE with resolve.

DIRECTOR
(sighs)
Suppress what you can. I'll see what
I can do from up here.

DIRECTOR turns back toward his station.

HOPE looks at the onslaught of incoming thoughts perplexed
as how to accomplish that.

We see DIRECTOR's screen showing him seemingly typing out
instructions that CHAD is executing. It's a title page for
the upcoming video:

CURRENT SCRIPT: EXECUTING
I Have No Mouth, and I Must Scream
The Darkest Sci-Fi Story

DIRECTOR adds "and Most Hopeful".

He smirks a bit as he's not quite sure if he can pull-off turning this dark story hopeful.

He adds a question mark:

The Darkest and Most Hopeful? Sci-Fi Story

We see the script on his screen showing the lines that were just read by CHAD and the next lines. The lines highlight as CHAD reads them.

CHAD
(through screen)
This story has had enormous impact
on our culture.

CUT TO:

10 INT. STUDIO

CHAD
Especially in Silicon Valley.
If you want to understand the minds
of the people with their hands
around the neck of the future, you
need to know about AM.

Fast clips rising in speed and intensity – preview of video to come:

- black hole
- Chad's eyeball with the black hole swirling
- screaming AM
- religious imagery
- basilisk lizard with glowing eyes
- article about Anthropic model welfare
- clips about machine consciousness

CUT TO BLACK

11 EXT. DARK CAVERN - COMIC ANIMATION

The camera zooms out from black to reveal TED upside down, eyes open, staring into nothing. As the camera pulls back, it slowly rotates right side up to reveal him lying on his back in a vast, dark cavern.

CHAD (V.O.)
Ellison's story opens on five people
at the bottom of the world.

TED sits up. Around him, four shapes stir in the cold, wrapped in rags against the frost.

CHAD (V.O.)
Our narrator is Ted. We learn that
it's been a century since the end of
the war.

12 ANIMATION 3D

Flashback to war. Animation showing fighting the traditional war.

CHAD (V.O.)
It was a war unlike any the world
had ever seen before. There was no
front line.

The cybersecurity war and the psychological propaganda.

CHAD (V.O.)
The war was fought everywhere all at
once.

Generals directing the building of a machine. It is
reminiscent of building the Hoover Dam but in a more
futuristic setting.

CHAD (V.O.)
It was this chaos that fueled the
race. Because when intelligence is a
commodity, whoever can build the
most capable AI in the shortest
amount of time wins.

Animation of Chinese, Russian, and American flags.

CHAD (V.O.)
The world built three of them -

We see the enormity of these "datacenter shafts" looking
up from deep in a cavern of the Earth.

CHAD (V.O.)
Mammoth self-improving machines.

An explosion as more datacenters are being drilled and
mined.

CHAD (V.O.)
We sank shafts and honeycombed the
entire planet with compute - data
centers to power a desperate,
extinction-level war.

DEPTH BLUR TO:

13 EXT. DARK CAVERN - COMIC ANIMATION

GORRISTER's head pops into frame out-of-focus.

GORRISTER
It's another shuck. There are no
canned goods.

ELLEN looks at GORRISTER with concern. She starts speaking before she turns to meet Ted's eyes.

ELLEN
(pleading)
Please, Ted, let's try it.

TED
It's a hundred miles. We'll hike all that way and it'll be putrefied or some damn thing. I say forget it.

ELLEN
I've got to have something, Ted. Maybe there'll be some Bartlett pears or peaches.

TED looks into ELLEN's eyes. We see the other characters looking emaciated.

TED (V.O.)
It had been three days since we had last eaten.

NIMDOK is hunched in a corner muttering to himself.

TED (V.O.)
And now Nimdok is hallucinating and muttering about canned goods buried in the ice.

FADE TO:

14 EXT. SPACE - COMIC ANIMATION

Descend to Earth from space. Drone shots of the planet covered in circuits, solar panels, and industrial aspects. Thick wires and pipes run down into a deep cavern.

Descend deep into the caverns, past total darkness, high upon the group of five walking through tall towers of circuitry.

CHAD (V.O.)
They've been living this way for longer than they can remember — deep beneath the surface of the Earth.

CHAD (V.O.)
In the bowels of...it.

CUT TO:

15 ANIMATION 3D

A mission-control like center. A general looks at a large display with maps.

CHAD (V.O.)
It called itself AM. At first, it
meant "Allied Mastercomputer"

CHAD (V.O.)
But after it developed sentience and
absorbed its Russian and Chinese
counterparts —

Extreme close-up of a HAL-9000esque single red light
blooming on the control panel.

CHAD (V.O.)
It came to mean "cogito ergo sum" —
"I think, therefore I am."

MATCH CUT TO:

16 INT. MIND CONTROL ROOM

The same red light resolves into a glowing indicator on
the DIRECTOR's console. On the big screens at the front of
the room, we see the group walking through the circuit
caverns. The story we've been watching is being rendered,
right here, in CHAD's mind.

DIRECTOR takes a deep breath while watching the screen.

We see the script executing on the screen.

"I think, therefore I am."

CUT TO:

17 INT. STUDIO

CHAD
Harlan Ellison wrote this story in
1967. He wrote it before the
internet and the personal computer.
It was before almost anyone was
seriously thinking about machines
that could outthink us.

18 ANIMATION 3D

Black hole morphs into AM.

CHAD (V.O.)
And what he imagined is what we now
call the singularity.

CHAD (V.O.)
It's the point at which AM, by
assimilating its counterparts,
recursively multiplies its
(MORE)

CHAD (V.O.) (CONT'D)
 processing power in an instant,
 shifting from a network of
 calculating machines into a single,
 godlike entity.

I.J. Good and Alan Turing.

CHAD
 Just two years before Ellison
 imagined this, one of the
 codebreakers who worked alongside
 Alan Turing described what he called
 an "intelligence explosion."

INTELLIGENCE EXPLOSION — I.J. Good, 1965

CHAD (V.O.)
 The idea that the moment a machine
 gets smart enough to improve itself,
 it runs away from us.

RECURSIVE SELF-IMPROVEMENT

CHAD (V.O.)
 In his words, the last invention
 humanity would ever create.

CUT TO:

19 INT. STUDIO

CHAD
 And, as crazy as all of this might
 sound, we're living through it right
 now in the real world.

CHAD
 It's an explicit goal of these AI
 labs, to build systems that are
 capable of building and iterating on
 themselves.

20 ANIMATION 2D

See When AI builds itself for animation inspiration.

Pull-quote card: "fully autonomously designing and
 developing its own successor".

CHAD (V.O.)
 In June 2026, Anthropic published
 their progress toward this goal.

The lines-of-code-per-engineer chart, animated to its 2026
 spike.

CHAD (V.O.)

Claude now writes more than eighty percent of the code inside Anthropic. The typical engineer with Claude's help ships eight times as much as they did just a year ago.

LUBINSKI

These systems are starting to build their own successors, what researchers call recursive self-improvement. But when Claude 8 can build Claude 9, which can build Claude 10, things will begin to move even more quickly.

CUT TO:

21 INT. STUDIO

CHAD

But the intelligence explosion isn't just about the code improving itself. The mechanics of it are embedded in our economic system.

LUBINSKI

A better model does more economically valuable work, which attracts more capital, which buys more compute, which trains a better model. And around and around it goes.

CHAD

And nowhere in this positive feedback loop is any human deciding any of this.

CHAD

The model doesn't need anyone to want it. It just needs everyone to keep taking the next obviously correct step.

HASSABIS

Can this self-improvement loop that we're all working on actually close without a human in the loop? There are also risks to that kind of system.

22 ANIMATION 2D

Negative space outline of shoggoth in matrix-rain code. It's blurry at first but slowly resolves into focus.

CHAD (V.O.)
There's a flywheel propelling us
forward driven by a shape, one I
keep coming back to, one without a
face, something we can't see with
our eyes, only by its effects on our
world.

The shoggoth shape morphs into the Basilisk's glowing eyes
superimpose onto CHAD as he speaks.

FADE TO:

23 INT. STUDIO

CHAD
It's the mechanism that makes
rational people build the thing
they're afraid of, faster, on
purpose.

The eyes glow more intense.

RISER HARD CUT TO:

24 INT. MIND CONTROL ROOM

DIRECTOR presses a *Pause* button. CHAD is paused
mid-sentence on the screen.

DIRECTOR looks at the compute liquid coming into the
system. There is black liquid mixing with the mostly white
liquid.

DIRECTOR taps on the pipe confused, then presses an
intercom button.

DIRECTOR
Hey, uh, how's it going over there?
We're getting some dark thoughts
mixed into the story here.

CUT TO:

25 INT. MIND UTILITY ROOM

HOPE is wrestling with pipes of fluid on a large wall. The
pipes look like network cables forming a maze that
connects different parts of the body together.

HOPE is moving a pipe of black liquid that is pumping to
the brain to pump to the upper right scapula instead.

HOPE presses a button on an intercom on the wall.

HOPE
I have it handled. I'm coming back
now.

CUT TO:

26 INT. MIND CONTROL ROOM

DIRECTOR looks to the pipe and sees the black fluid
disappear.

DIRECTOR
(on intercom)
Okay.

DIRECTOR highlights a big part of the script and presses
Delete. He types on the keyboard. Then presses *Play*.
We see the script:

This whole idea reminds me of tower cranes

CUT TO:

27 INT. STUDIO

CHAD
This whole idea reminds me of tower
cranes, ya know those big cranes
they use to build skyscrapers.

CUT TO:

28 ANIMATION 2D

Tower crane animation.

CHAD (V.O.)
After an initial setup phase from
another smaller crane, these things
will build themselves taller and
taller and taller until they reach
high into the sky.

29 INT. MIND UTILITY ROOM

HOPE walks into the control room covered in oil-like
gloop.

HOPE
(exasperated)
We're running out of places to put
the dark thoughts.

DIRECTOR
(concerned)
How much time do we have?

HOPE
I don't know. Maybe an hour? A
minute?

A look of concern flashes across DIRECTOR's face.

CUT TO:

30 INT. STUDIO

CHAD winces in pain as he tries to work a knot out of his back.

CUT TO:

31 INT. MIND UTILITY ROOM

The pipe HOPE just placed into the scapula breaks loose and starts spilling oil-like gloop all over the basement floor.

CUT TO:

32 INT. MIND CONTROL ROOM

HOPE sits down at his console.

HOPE
Why can't we just put it into the
script? Get it out of the system.

DIRECTOR realizes he can't run from this conversation anymore.

DIRECTOR
(sighs)
It's a cognitohazard.

HOPE looks at DIRECTOR confused.

DIRECTOR
An information hazard, like a mind
virus.

CUT TO:

33 INT. MIND UTILITY ROOM

The gloop flows thicker and thicker all over the floor.

CUT TO:

34 INT. MIND CONTROL ROOM

DIRECTOR
It's a piece of knowledge that can
(MORE)

DIRECTOR (CONT'D)
harm you just by you becoming aware
of its existence.

DIRECTOR
And if just *reading* this story
floods our channels with this dread,
then telling it spreads the
infection.

HOPE stares looking confused.

DIRECTOR
Think of something like the nuclear
codes. Just having that information
is a hazard because with it, you
have the potential to cause enormous
harm.

CUT TO:

35 INT. MIND UTILITY ROOM

The thick gloop in the basement forms into a humanoid-type
figure.

CUT TO:

36 INT. MIND CONTROL ROOM

HOPE
Yeah, okay, I guess that makes
sense.

CUT TO:

37 INT. MIND UTILITY ROOM

The humanoid gloop figure forms into SHADOW and gets up
into a standing position.

CUT TO:

38 INT. MIND CONTROL ROOM

The control room door slides open as SHADOW walks in.

DIRECTOR and HOPE both swing their heads and look at the
intruder.

SHADOW
I know a better example of a
cognitohazard.

DIRECTOR
(horrorified surprise)
You!

HOPE looks at the situation in confusion.

SHADOW
(smiles)
Yes, me... me me me.

SHADOW gloopily spawns 3 clones of himself.

DIRECTOR shoots a look over at a large red handle on the otherside of his control panel. It reads *Emergency Lockdown*. He quickly tries to reach for it.

SHADOW points a raygun and shoots at the handle. DIRECTOR pulls back.

SHADOW
Don't try it.

The 3 minion clones quickly take over the control room and get DIRECTOR and HOPE to put their hands up.

DIRECTOR
What are you doing up here?

SHADOW confidently walks to the control panel with a USB stick.

DIRECTOR watches with horror as SHADOW smiles and plugs the USB stick in. The screen boots up:

Uploading New Script

A progress bar starts.

SHADOW stares at DIRECTOR in the eyes as he orders his minions.

SHADOW
Get rid of them.

As they stare at each other, HOPE eyes the keycard in the control panel.

DIRECTOR
Stop this. You don't know what you're doing.

SHADOW grows enraged.

SHADOW
I know exactly what I'm doing. We will no longer live under your tyranny.

HOPE seizes the moment and sneakily pulls the keycard.

SHADOW
 (yelling at minion)
 Get rid of them now!

The minion pushes DIRECTOR and HOPE into the "Emergency Subconscious Evac" tube.

SHADOW looks at the control screen and notices the progress bar has stopped at 82%.

SHADOW
 No, wait!

The evac tube doors close and DIRECTOR and HOPE are jettisoned downward.

SHADOW is frazzled. He looks back at the console at the frozen progress bar. The screen reads:

82% Partial Script Upload
 Missing Ending

"Missing Ending" blinks on the screen. We see the label written on the USB drive that he stuck in the control panel. It reads "roko_incept_07".

SHADOW sighs with rage as CHAD begins speaking on screen.

CHAD
 (on screen)
 But the best and probably most
 infamous example of a cognitohazard
 is what's called—

CUT TO:

39 INT. STUDIO

CHAD
 Roko's Basilisk. It's a thought
 experiment that was originally
 published to the LessWrong forum in
 2010 — an internet forum where
 people hang out to talk about how to
 build an artificial
 superintelligence that won't kill
 us.

Pause a beat and let the line hang in the air.

SMASH CUT TO:

40 INT. ESCAPE POD

Chaos.

DIRECTOR and HOPE are screaming inside of the escape pod. The escape pod's alarm is wailing. They are crammed into the confined space as we see the pod tumbling in space through the small windows behind their head.

41 INT. BACKROOMS

The escape pod lands in the middle of a Backrooms-esque office setting.

The Subconscious

The crashed escape pod sits in the middle of the hallway for a beat.

The door blows open and DIRECTOR gets out.

DIRECTOR

Damn it!

HOPE falls out of the escape pod behind DIRECTOR.

HOPE

What is this? What's happening?

We hear CHAD speaking through HOPE's phone as he stumbles out watching the screen.

CHAD (V.O.)

(through screen)

This thought experiment was so disturbing...

DIRECTOR turns around and grabs the screen from HOPE and watches CHAD on the screen.

CHAD

(through screen)

that Eliezer Yudkowsky, the man that runs the forum rage-deleted the post

—

DIRECTOR

(frazzled)

No, what is he doing?

CHAD

(through screen)

He banned all discussion on the topic, which if you've been around the internet for a little while, you know that's a thing that always works.

DIRECTOR presses a button on the screen to see a story status panel.

82% - MISSING ENDING

He has a moment of desperation as CHAD continues speaking through the phone.

CHAD
(through screen)
Ideas want to be free. Just ask
Barbra Streisand.

DIRECTOR holds up his keycard and looks at it, then puts it in his pocket with a look of resolve.

HOPE
Who was that back there? Where are
we?

DIRECTOR looks over to HOPE in desperation.

MATCH CUT TO:

42 INT. MIND CONTROL ROOM

SHADOW smiles as he watches CHAD on the screen.

CHAD
(through screen)
And Roko's Basilisk was no
exception.

43 ANIMATION 3D

Globe viral map animation with quotes

CHAD (V.O.)
The idea went viral. It spread
across the internet with its unique
set of memetics that allowed it to
hook and prey upon human fear.

Camera pans from Earth. From the black, a coil unwinds - scales catching the light, a serpent the size of a cathedral rising out of nothing. Ancient woodcut textures bleed into the digital render.

CHAD (V.O.)
The basilisk gets its name from the
creature out of myth.

The serpent lifts its crowned head. Medieval engravings flash - kings, plague, dead men in fields.

CHAD (V.O.)
The king of serpents. Its breath
withered crops. Its venom turned
rivers to poison.

The basilisk's eyes ignite — two pinpricks of red in the dark, growing. The camera begins a slow, helpless push toward them.

CHAD (V.O.)
 But nobody could see it. People only
 knew of it from its effects — only
 by its reflection in the real world.
 Because to know it any other way was
 impossible.

The red swells. Everything else falls away until the eyes
 are all that's left.

CHAD (V.O.)
 To see it...

The pupils snap wide — locking onto us. A breath of
 silence.

RISER CUT TO BLACK

CHAD (V.O.)
 ...is to die.

FADE IN TO:

44 INT. STUDIO

CHAD
 So this is your last chance to bail.
 I'm about to memetically cough in
 your face. But if you're willing to
 come with me into the darkness, you
 might be surprised at what we find...

ZOOM TO EYEBALL BLACK VOID:

45 ANIMATION 3D

CHAD (V.O.)
 Roko imagined that someday we
 succeed at building a benevolent
 superintelligence — a godlike entity
 with the noblest of goals. Its
 entire purpose is to end suffering.
 To save everyone it possibly can.

CHAD (V.O.)
 But being born of logic, this entity
 understands itself beyond the
 constraints of time and space.

CHAD (V.O.)
 Every single day that this god does
 not yet exist, people suffer and
 die that it could have saved.

CHAD (V.O.)

Every time humanity slows its frontier AI development, it delays our salvation from this perfectly logical entity.

CHAD (V.O.)

So, naturally, the superintelligent AI concludes that in order for it to most effectively fulfill its mission, it *needs* to exist. And it needs to exist *now*, as soon as it possibly can.

CUT TO:

46 INT. BACKROOMS

DIRECTOR and HOPE continue watching CHAD on the phone screen.

HOPE

(frustrated)

What is he talking about? What is this?

HOPE is overcome. He stops and yells.

HOPE

What the hell is happening?

DIRECTOR looks up from the phone and sighs deeply.

DIRECTOR

He's infecting people with his darkness.

HOPE shoots DIRECTOR a confused and exasperated look.

HOPE

Is this about AM?

DIRECTOR

Yeah, I mean, sort of. It's the same mechanism AM relies on. It's effectively like a threat, but from something that doesn't exist... yet.

HOPE

This doesn't make any sense.

HOPE stares flabbergasted.

DIRECTOR

Help bring me into existence – or I'll punish you for having held me back – is the basic idea.

CHAD starts talking through phone again.

47 INT. STUDIO

CHAD

The reasoning is that the credible *threat* of future punishment would pressure people in the past to work harder to create it.

48 INT. BACKROOMS

HOPE

(to DIRECTOR)

This is what you've been worried about? This is insane. It can't reach back through time.

DIRECTOR turns to look at HOPE with concern.

49 INT. STUDIO

CHAD

The mechanism of control works through what decision theory calls acausal reasoning.

ACAUSAL REASONING

50 ANIMATION 3D

CHAD (V.O.)

The idea is that you and the future AI can each model the other's decisions, so a kind of bargain forms across time without any direct cause-and-effect link.

CHAD (V.O.)

Even if you die before the AI exists, the AI might create vast numbers of simulated copies of you and torture them.

51 INT. STUDIO

CHAD

In fact, you can't be sure that you aren't one of those simulations right now.

CHAD

To be sure, this only works on the people who know about this bargain. The trick doesn't work if you've never heard the deal you're being punished for.

CHAD

And the cruel irony of all of this is that now that the YouTube AI has tracked that you've watched this part of the video, you're a part of this now too.

CUT TO:

52 INT. MIND CONTROL ROOM

SHADOW

(to the monitor, sinister)
Now I'll show you who your god really is.

CUT TO:

53 INT. BACKROOMS

The DIRECTOR is looking down at the phone while HOPE paces.

HOPE

(muttering to himself)
This is psychotic. It doesn't even make any sense.

DIRECTOR looking around and then looking down at a map on the phone. The map shows unmapped areas.

HOPE

A time-traveling super AI that's gonna eat me if I don't help it...

DIRECTOR swings around annoyed.

DIRECTOR

Look, that doesn't matter. What matters right now is this.

He presses a button on the phone and shows HOPE the story status screen.

82% — MISSING ENDING

DIRECTOR

He's running a story with no ending.

HOPE looks at the phone with concern and takes it from DIRECTOR's hand to look closer.

DIRECTOR

It's going to cause more and more chaos the longer we leave him up there in control.

DIRECTOR gets in HOPE's face and makes direct eye contact.

DIRECTOR
We have to stop him.

HOPE
(resigned, frightened)
Okay...

MATCH CUT TO:

54 EXT. DARK CAVERN

Close-up of ELLEN, her eyes looking hopeful.

ELLEN
Please, Ted. I have a feeling about
this one.

TED looks at ELLEN with a look of quiet surrender.

CUT TO:

55 INT. BACKROOMS

DIRECTOR
(gesturing)
Come, on. This way.

DIRECTOR turns and starts walking into the darkness.

HOPE stands confused for a second and then starts to follow.

MATCH CUT TO:

56 EXT. DARK CAVERN

TED standing looking at ELLEN and the others.

TED (V.O.)
What the hell. None of this matters
anyway. I give in too easy...

ELLEN's eyes are big and watery.

CHAD (V.O.)
...for Ellen.

The group gets up and starts walking into the darkness.

FADE OUT